

### **Project 3**

**Course Code and Name:** MSJ2201 Mass Communication

**Project Name:** Behind the Screen

**Project Type:** Mask Making

**Semester of Submission:** Summer 2023

#### **Project Description:**

This project explored the relationship between social media and the mental and social well-being of young people. It focused on group polarization and how social media can influence people's thoughts and emotions. A conceptual mask was created to show two contrasting sides of youth. One side represented a happy and socially active person, while the other showed isolation and emotional distress. Symbols like a smartphone and a handmade knife were used to communicate the impact of social media and overthinking. The mask was exhibited at Bangladesh Shilpakala Academy, where viewers were interviewed about the effectiveness of the concept.

#### **Project Justification:**

The project highlighted the growing impact of social media on young people's emotional and social well-being. While social media helps people connect, excessive use, trolling, and social comparison can cause loneliness, anxiety, and distress. The mask was used to show the difference between how people appear and what they may feel inside. It helped visually communicate the hidden emotional effects of social media.



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UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS  
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Mask Report

Course: Mass Communication

Title: Polarization of Youths' Mental Health by Social Media

Done by:

Group 9

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**C.I:** When teaching a topic, curriculum integration (CI) refers to merging two or more subjects. Integrating ideas, content (the facts or substantive knowledge), and competences (or abilities) produced in a topic are all parts of CI. One of the core ideas of twenty-first century learning has recently come back into focus: curriculum integration. Curriculum integration is frequently associated with inquiry-based learning in this setting. The reasoning behind this is that in order to properly study an issue or a topic in an authentic inquiry context, learners must make use of multiple subjects. The subject concepts and information from the various subjects must complement one another for CI to be effective and have the ability to increase student knowledge. Our mask's theme was group polarization, which, in social psychology, refers to a group's propensity to adopt viewpoints that are more extreme than those of its individual members. When one's social focus or conversation causes a group to adopt attitudes or behaviors that are more extreme than the initial attitudes or behaviors of the individual group member, this is known as group polarization.

**C.I Theme:** There is a big issue with anxiety, mental trauma, and despair in our generation. However, neither the family nor the friends seem to get it; instead, they try to paint me as an introvert. Even the family is unwilling to listen or acknowledge. The family and society should acknowledge and address this issue. Social media now permeates every aspect of daily life. Young people and adolescents use social media the most frequently. We get to connect more through social media than by seeing each other and communicating. In our personal life, we also use social media as our primary source for communication with friends and family. Our social life is primarily based on social media. So this field piqued our interest to work on.

**Our message:** The way we communicate is evolving in this day and age. Looking at a screen is considered communication. On social media, trolling is becoming common practice. The impact of our words on the other person is not something we hear or see. Surprisingly, it's also simple to experience loneliness in the midst of all that hyper connection. This generation today, for one thing, are depressingly certain when they are being ignored. On the other side, other children are having fun with their friends. Through social media, they can converse more easily. It has both beneficial and detrimental effects.

**Layout:** As social media polarized the mental state of youths', we decided to paint half of the mask as a jovial side (who interacts with almost everyone), and the other half somber type (whose interaction with everyone is low). We attached an additional hand painted smart phone

and a handmade knife made out of plaster. The phone signifies the medium of social media by which teenagers are being affected, and the knife was attached to the right side of the board (depressed side), to signify the "over thinking kills" message. On the right side of the board (happy side), we used texts (adjectives) to highlight the characteristics of the person affected by social media, and on the left side we used phrases that are anti-social.

**Painting and Installation:** We painted our mask using acrylic paint and paint brushes of various sizes. An additional smart phone and a knife made of plaster was attached to the frame. The only problem we faced was when we could not decide on the coloring contrast to match our ideas, but after a discussion we were able to sort out the color combinations that would work well with the mask.

**Exhibition:** The exhibition was held in Shilpakala Academy, exhibition gallery: 7 (level: 3), Jatiya Chitrashala. Rezwan Shahriar Sumit, renowned and award-winning filmmaker, was present as the special guest in this event. Professor Jude William Genilo, pro vice-chancellor of ULAB, respected faculties of ULAB, students of ULAB and few other visitors were present in this exhibition. There would be no better exposition for our mask presentation than Shilpakala academy, as our group got a fair amount of feedback and praise towards our presentation. Our display is accentuated by the gallery's lighting systems.

**Feedback:** Interviewed guests included students and faculties from ULAB. We chose to question whether they understood our topic by looking at our masks, whether the mask clearly illustrates the mental effects on the teenagers and whether there were any lacking or methods to improve the mask. From the spectators' opinions, our teams got the clear idea that the spectators could easily grasp the idea we intended to show visually with our mask. Moreover, there were no additional suggestions on how we could have improved the mask in a different way.

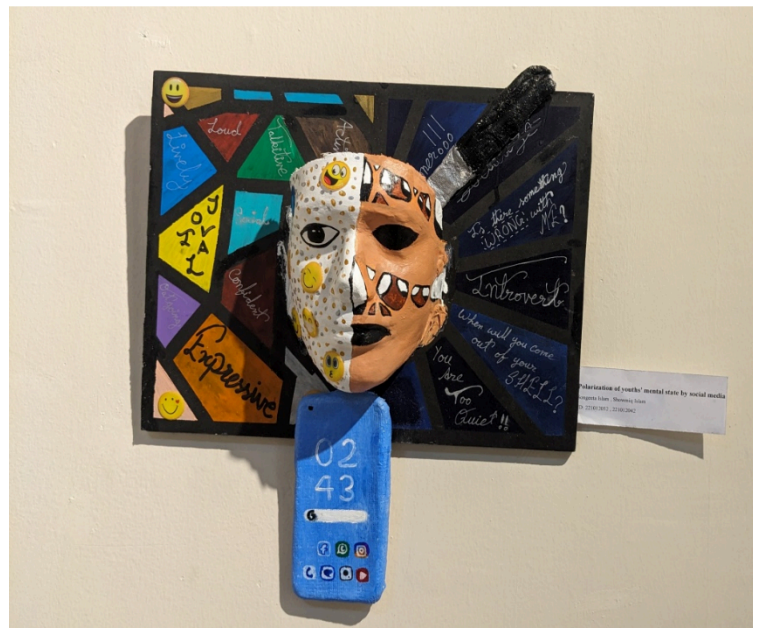
**Realization:** At the conclusion of the exhibition, our team realized our mask delivered a clear message to the audiences who were a part of this exhibition. The bright colors on one side and the dark shades on the other, assisted the viewers to understand transparently, the effects on the mental state of a youth by social media.

**Role of individual members:**

Songeeta Islam: Molded the mask from plaster to the final product.

Showmiq Islam Utshow: Painted the mask and made additional materials attached to the frame.

## Photographs:



**Conclusion:** Today's youth will grow up to be adults who are apprehensive about talking, our species' fundamental form of communication, if they don't have enough practice connecting with people and having their needs met in person and in real time. Of course, when people age and start negotiating love relationships and jobs, social negotiations only become riskier.

**Learnings and Outcomes:**

- Understand group polarization and how group interactions can influence attitudes and behaviors.
- Explore the psychological effects of social media on young people.
- Learn to communicate complex social issues through visual storytelling.
- Develop conceptual thinking by converting an abstract idea into a physical artwork.
- Learn how symbolism works in visual communication.
- Improve presentation and communication skills through interaction with exhibition visitors. Understand the importance of empathy when discussing youth mental and emotional experiences.
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